WHEN HIS TEAM told Karan Bhangay, Founder, Indulge, about the call from Gujarat, their advice was to skip it. Bhangay, however, wasn't convinced.

"I looked up the name, the business, and decided to make the call," he says. "But I still had to convince my team, which was adamant there was no business for us there."

The caller wanted a VIP *darshan* for his parents at the Siddhivinayak temple in Mumbai. But he spoke Gujarati, and his request did not come across clearly. "He had made money in business. But he couldn't communicate in English, and that was the whole problem," says Bhangay. "He had everything and still felt he didn't belong."

Bhangay took the call and handled the whole trip: the travel, the hotel, and the *darshan*. The man became a member and, Bhangay says, a client for life. The episode captures a challenge for concierge firms as they automate more of their work. Technology can fulfil a request, but understanding the person making it still requires human judgement.

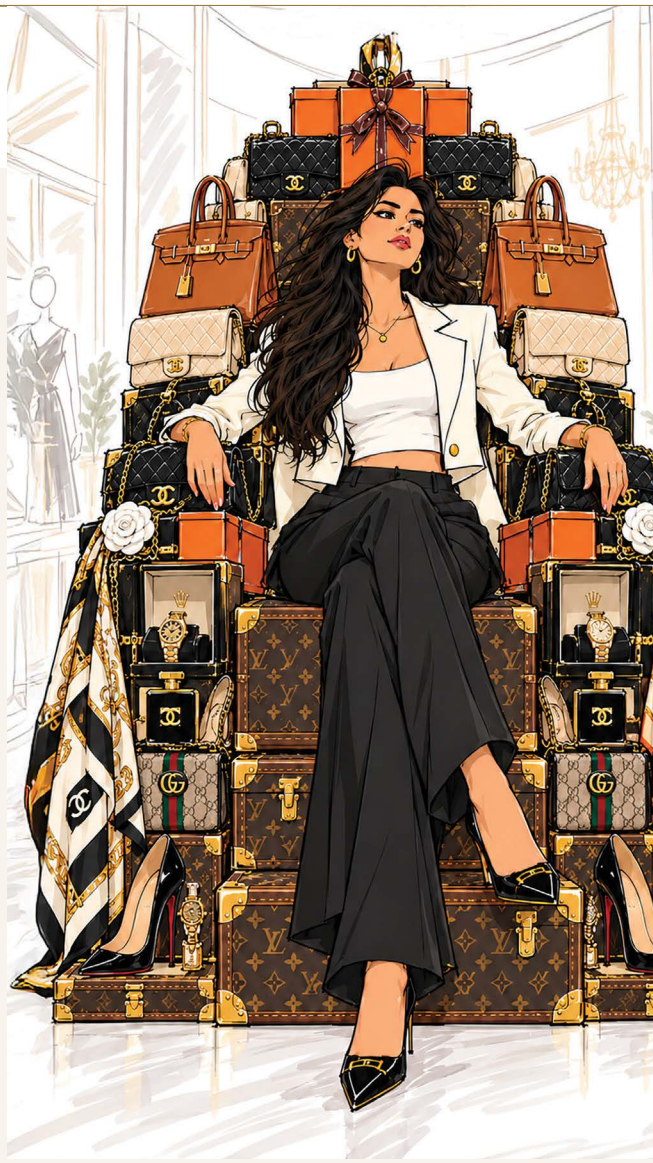
CURATING A LIFESTYLE

From a champagne breakfast at Everest base camp to Wimbledon tickets secured in 48 hours and a same-weekend table at a three-Michelin-star restaurant, Bhangay has built a business around making the improbable feel routine. Indian wealth, he says, is less about owning and more about validation, proof that "we have made it". Often, that proof is access to places or to people.

Bhangay founded Indulge, a members-only concierge service, with Advita Bihani in Goa in 2022. Members pay ₹4 lakh a year for a team on WhatsApp, 24/7, that handles travel, dining, access, sourcing and anything else legal. The company says it operates in more than 180 countries.

In September, Indulge announced that it had closed a $1 million pre-Series A round. It had raised a similar amount the previous year. The latest fundraise will help the company expand into Malaysia, South Africa, Dubai and the US, and spend more on artificial intelligence (AI).

The bet is that AI will absorb the routine work—checking availability, drafting options, pre-filling details—so the team can focus on requests that turn on judgement, relationships and, as with the client from Gujarat, belonging. "AI," says Bhangay, "will help us eliminate human error."



He is not alone. From Mumbai to Menlo Park, AI is altering workflows of lifestyle and concierge companies, though in different ways, and even bringing new companies into the segment. Meta's Muse can book travel, make appointments, and shop on a user's behalf. Aprameya Radhakrishna is building Littl, an AI assistant that he says can "run your life". At Quintessentially, AI is helping teams research faster, organise information and streamline routine processes. Les Concierges and Club Concierge have been using an AI assistant called Mira since early 2025.

CURRENCY OF TIME

For decades, the concierge business has rested on